

Internet on your TV

According to analysts, 25 per cent of the TVs sold next year will be internet-enabled



Dell Venue launched

Dell launched its Android 2.2 phone, the Dell Venue globally. It features a 4.1-inch AMOLED screen and an 8MP camera

SHOPPING

We devoted considerable amount of time and energy to this category. The reasons are obvious

– it's perhaps be the most relevant category to you readers and we always want you to make the right choices when it comes to buying tech products. This category is special also because surprisingly, when it comes to tech shopping web sites the universe is very large. In fact we had to go ahead and sub-categorise it into Consumer Tech and Tech Components. The former encompasses around 20 web sites that deal in gadgets and electronics such as phones, laptops, printers, tablets, e-readers, PMPs and many more. The Tech Components category on the other hand compared eight of the best web sites that dealt with PC hardware – we're talking about hardcore geek stuff – graphics cards, HDDs, memory, processors et al.

We had a rigorous test process that took into account a number of factors including scoring for things like number of categories, comparative prices, availability of specialised products, payment options etc.

But as we got closer to our results a strange debate started to ensue within the team. The topic of online shopping divided Team Digit, and the generally docile geeks were up in arms at the middle of the night. Several personal narrations and a Facebook post later (*see box "What you said..."*), we reached a conclusion.

The topic in question was whether a large percentage of net savvy Indians shop online in the first place, or is the general junta still afraid of e-commerce. It turns out that while the number is increasing rapidly, majority of Indians are still conservative about anything that has to do with money and online. We expect people to fraud us, and sites to rob us the moment we put the smallest detail of our bank/card accounts online. These fears are not born out of nothing. Our sympathies are with everyone who have been duped by well known sites and sellers. But perhaps we're all realising it's time to put these fears aside and take a dip (if not a dive) in the waters of online shopping.

Consumer tech

There are several classes of products that make up consumer tech. In the following writeup we try to discuss various options for some of these and then eventually, based on the scores come up with an overall winner that can be regarded as the best overall destination for consumer tech shopping.

Mobile-havens

Mobiles are the most sought after gadget these days, and there are portals dedicated for selling just them. A general trend we observed was that these stores are backed by a popular retail chains. Probably the most popular mobile selling chain is Mobile Store. Its web site is slightly disappointing compared to BigCMobiles.in, that offered much better deals. But, BigCMobiles could do some work on their site, as it is very buggy. But the best of the lot is without doubt Univercell.in, selling more than 800 different models at the most competitive prices. Again, the chain from Chennai hasn't done much work on their site. We would have particularly liked to see some proper filters on this site, something that the huge collection demanded.

Market places

eBay is a marketplace of huge proportions, and unlike the online shops in this test, eBay is just a collection of sellers, big and small, who come and sell their products on the site. As a web site, we found eBay to be fairly decent. Extremely easy to browse around, eBay has excellent filters that help you choose from the wide variety available. But we still don't find eBay searchable enough, mainly because a search for 'Nokia N8' would throw up N8 models from all the sellers on the web site, without any sort of grouping. And thrown in the mix are screen guards and cases. Combine this with the fact that you must not forget to check the filter for displaying only 'New' products is irritating. Seller reputation is

the indicator of honesty on eBay, but we wonder how difficult it is for sellers to fake that. eBay, on their part, have introduced a system called PaisaPay, under which they don't pay the amount to the seller until your units are delivered. But does it ensure quality of the product? eBay may be the 'go to' place for online shopping of all kinds, but when it comes to consumer tech, the experience was a little lacklustre. Indiatimes Shopping is another marketplace. Nowhere close to the proportions of eBay, the only thing we can say is that it makes search easier, which is probably due to the limited number of sellers.

The notables

In the last few years, many online shopping sites have cropped up, leading to many innovations being introduced by these sellers. Smartshoppers.in for example,

has a decent collection of laptops, with a notable quantity of cameras and other photography equipment. The site stood out for its five days "no questions asked" return policy on most offers. Whether it is honoured, when invoked, is something you readers can tell us in your feedback. Tradus.in provides free shipping and a good 15 days return policy. AdexMart offers free shipping as well as transit-insurance on the products, along with Warranty and bill. It also delivers product on Cash-on-delivery basis in some cities.

And the winner is...

Infibeam is one of the most impressive sites in our test. Excellent deals, accompa-